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At the end of World War II, I was a New Dealer to the core. I thought government could solve all our postwar problems just as it had ended the Depression and won the war. I didn't trust big business. I thought government, not private companies, should own our big public utilities; if there wasn't enough housing to shelter the American people, I thought government should build it; if we needed better medical care, the answer was socialized medicine.

My brother, meanwhile, had decided to become a Republican. We spent hours arguing—sometimes with pretty strong language—over the future of the country. He complained about the growth of government, claimed Washington was trying to take over everything in the American economy from the railroads to the corner store, and said we couldn't trust our wartime ally, Russia, any longer. I claimed he was just spouting Republican propaganda.

Like a lot of people in my generation, I'd come out of the Depression and a war expecting a better and more equitable world. I really thought we had fought a war to end all wars.

But I didn't like some of the things I saw after VJ Day.

If you wanted to buy a new car, a salesman told you it was available only if you paid a sizable fee under the table. This didn't sit well with those of us who had been in uniform for four or five years. Meanwhile, old patterns of racism were reappearing after four years in which blacks and whites had fought side by side. My own industry, motion pictures, was being ripped apart by a bitter labor dispute. What troubled